

SOMUN’26

Background Guide

UNGA:The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC)

AGENDA: Autonomous Weapons: The Impact on Terrorism and the Human Cost of War

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Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

It is our pleasure to welcome you to SOMUN'26 and the United Nations General Assembly First Committee on Disarmament and International Security — UNGA DISEC.

We understand that MUN can be an overwhelming experience, particularly for first-time delegates. With new procedures, unfamiliar terminology, and the pressure of representing a country, it is natural to feel uncertain at first. We hope that this committee serves not only as a platform for debate, but also as an opportunity to learn, grow, and find confidence in your voice.

DISEC brings together some of the most significant questions surrounding international peace, disarmament, and security. We look forward to hearing the perspectives you bring to these discussions and witnessing the diplomacy, negotiation, and collaboration that shape the committee.

As your Executive Board, we hope to create an environment that is engaging, respectful, and encouraging, where every delegate can participate meaningfully, regardless of their level of experience.

Do not be afraid to speak, to question, or even to make mistakes. MUN is, at its heart, a learning experience.

We look forward to welcoming you to committee and making SOMUN'26 a memorable experience for each of you.

Warm regards,
The Executive Board,

Chairperson:Sai Sushankh Jetty

Vice-chairperson:Anjana Sai Anne

Rapporteur:Abiram.K

INTRODUCTION TO COMMITTEE

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), formally known as the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly, is the principal General Assembly forum for matters concerning disarmament, arms control and international security.

The Committee's mandate derives primarily from Chapter IV, Article 11 of the Charter of the United Nations, which empowers the General Assembly to consider principles governing disarmament and the regulation of armaments and to make recommendations to Member States or the Security Council.

DISEC addresses issues ranging from nuclear disarmament and non-proliferation to conventional weapons, arms transfers and emerging security challenges. It provides Member States with a platform to debate these issues, negotiate proposals and work towards common recommendations.

Importantly, DISEC is a deliberative and recommending body, not an enforcement body. Its resolutions are recommendations of the General Assembly and do not carry the same binding authority as decisions adopted by the Security Council under its relevant powers. The Committee therefore relies on diplomacy, negotiation, consensus-building and international cooperation rather than enforcement.

For this agenda, DISEC will examine the security and humanitarian implications of autonomous weapons systems, with particular attention to human control, accountability, civilian protection, proliferation and international peace and security.

INTRODUCTION TO AGENDA

Autonomous Weapons: The Impact on Terrorism and the Human Cost of War

Warfare is undergoing a major technological shift. Advances in **artificial intelligence, robotics, sensors and autonomous systems** are allowing weapons to perform increasingly complex functions with limited human intervention.

An **autonomous weapon system (AWS)** is generally understood as a weapon system that, once activated, can independently select and engage targets without further human intervention. However, there is currently **no universally accepted international definition of autonomous weapons**, and autonomy should not automatically be equated with artificial intelligence or remote-controlled weapons. The central concern is the degree of independence a system has in the **selection and engagement of targets**

The debate therefore extends beyond technology. It concerns **international security, civilian protection, accountability, human control, proliferation, escalation, ethics and the future conduct of warfare**.

1. HUMAN CONTROL AND ACCOUNTABILITY

The central issue is whether meaningful **human control and human responsibility** can be maintained when autonomous systems are used.

Autonomy cannot itself become a substitute for legal responsibility. Existing international law places obligations on **States and individuals**, not on machines. The ICRC has therefore emphasized human judgement, predictability, supervision and accountability in discussions on autonomous weapons. (icrc.org)

2. INTERNATIONAL PEACE AND SECURITY

As a DISEC agenda, autonomous weapons must also be examined through the broader question of international security.

Chapter IV, Article 11 of the UN Charter provides the General Assembly with a role in considering principles governing **disarmament and the regulation of armaments** and making recommendations to Member States or the Security Council. (un.org)

3. TERRORISM AND PROLIFERATION

Another major concern is the possible spread of increasingly autonomous military technologies to **non-State actors**, including terrorist organizations and armed groups.

Delegates should examine:

- international export controls;
- prevention of diversion;
- responsible arms transfers;
- protection against unauthorized acquisition;
- international cooperation;
- mechanisms for controlling proliferation.

However, delegates should not assume that autonomous weapons will automatically make terrorism more dangerous. The relevant question is **under what circumstances their proliferation could create new security risks**.

4. THE LEGAL AND ETHICAL DILEMMA

The debate ultimately has two connected dimensions.

The **legal question** is:

Can autonomous weapons be developed and used consistently with existing international law?

The **ethical and political question** is:

Should machines be permitted to make decisions that directly determine the use of lethal force?

This creates three broad policy approaches for delegates to investigate:

Prohibition — banning certain autonomous weapons or functions.

Strict regulation — allowing some systems while establishing internationally agreed restrictions and requirements for meaningful human control.

Existing-law approach — relying primarily on existing IHL, weapons reviews and national measures while improving responsible use.

There is **no universal agreement among States on which approach should be adopted**.

5. WHAT DELEGATES SHOULD RESEARCH

THE CORE QUESTION

This agenda is therefore **not simply about whether AI should be used in warfare**. It is about determining **where human responsibility and control must remain as military technology becomes increasingly autonomous**.

DISEC must consider whether the international community can establish common rules that protect civilians, prevent irresponsible proliferation and preserve accountability **without unnecessarily restricting legitimate technological and defensive capabilities**.

International Legal Framework

There is no single universally binding treaty that comprehensively regulates every autonomous weapon system. This does not mean that such weapons exist outside international law. Existing rules continue to apply according to their scope, including the UN Charter, International Humanitarian Law, applicable international human rights law and relevant arms control obligations. States disagree about whether these rules are sufficient or whether additional, weapon specific rules are needed.

For debate, distinguish three things: 1) a binding treaty obligation; 2) a political commitment or General Assembly resolution; and 3) a proposal that states are still negotiating. They do not have the same legal effect.

- **International Humanitarian Law**(IHL)

also known as the law of armed conflict(LOAC), regulates the conduct of hostilities and protects people who are not, or are no longer, participating in them. Its rules apply to the use of weapons regardless of whether a system incorporates autonomous functions.

- **Distinction** — separating civilians and civilian objects from military objectives.
- **Proportionality** — preventing attacks where expected civilian harm would be excessive in relation to the anticipated military advantage.
- **Precautions in attack** — taking feasible measures to protect civilians.

- IHL operates on a fundamental baseline: even in the chaos of war, military force is not unrestricted. It aims to protect people who are not, or are no longer, taking part in fighting (such as civilians and wounded soldiers) and to restrict the methods and means of warfare available to militaries

- ## Geneva Conventions and Additional Protocol I

  The four Geneva Conventions of 1949 establish central protections for wounded and sick members of armed forces, shipwrecked personnel, prisoners of war and civilians during armed conflict. Additional Protocol I of 1977 develops rules governing the conduct of hostilities in international armed conflicts. The provisions below are particularly relevant to weapons reviews and civilian protection.

  1. **Article 35, Additional Protocol I:** Sets fundamental limits on the means and methods of warfare, including prohibitions concerning superfluous injury or unnecessary suffering and weapons with indiscriminate effects.

  2. **Article 36, Additional Protocol I** : Requires each State Party to determine whether the employment of a new weapon, means or method of warfare would be prohibited under the Protocol or other applicable international law in some or all circumstances.

  3. **Article 48, Additional Protocol I** : Sets out the basic rule of distinction between civilians and combatants and between civilian objects and military objectives.

  4. **Articles 51 and 52, Additional Protocol I :** Protect civilians and civilian objects, including through prohibitions on indiscriminate attacks and rules governing military objectives.

  5. **Article 57, Additional Protocol I**: Requires feasible precautions in attack to protect civilians and civilian

Article 36 is especially relevant because it requires a legal review before a new weapon, means or method of warfare is used by a State Party to Additional Protocol I. It should not be described as a treaty obligation binding every state in exactly the same way. Other applicable treaty and customary rules must also be considered

- ## The Charter of the United Nations

  Article 2(4) of the UN Charter generally prohibits the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state, or in any other manner inconsistent with the purposes of the United Nations. Article 51 recognises the inherent right of individual or collective self defence if an armed attack occurs, subject to the Charter. These rules concern whether force may lawfully be used between states. International Humanitarian Law, by contrast, governs how hostilities are conducted once an armed conflict exists. This distinction matters because a

weapon might be used in a way that complies with the rules governing attacks, while the wider use of force may still breach the UN Charter. Conversely, a lawful resort to force does not remove the obligation to comply with International Humanitarian Law.

- ## Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons

  The Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW) is a principal multilateral forum for discussions on lethal autonomous weapon systems The CCW process has produced agreed guiding principles and sustained technical and diplomatic discussion, but it has not resulted in a comprehensive, universally binding treaty specifically regulating all LAWS. A major challenge is reaching agreement on definitions, the degree of human control required and the balance between humanitarian safeguards and states' security concerns.

- ## UN General Assembly resolutions

  1. **A/RES/78/241 (2023)** The General Assembly advanced consideration of autonomous weapon systems and sought views from states on the issue.
  2. **A/RES/79/62 (2024)** Continued the General Assembly's consideration of the legal, humanitarian, security and ethical implications.
  3. **A/RES/80/57 (2025)** Adopted on 1 December 2025 by 164 votes in favour, 6 against and 7 abstentions. It notes concerns including arms race risks, miscalculation, escalation and proliferation to unauthorised recipients and non State actors

General Assembly resolutions are generally recommendatory rather than binding treaties. Their text can nonetheless express a significant political position, request further work and help shape international discussion. Delegates should consult the operative paragraphs before claiming that a resolution creates a specific legal obligation.

- ## Arms transfers and counterterrorism

  The Arms Trade Treaty regulates international transfers of conventional arms within its scope. It requires states parties to assess specified risks before authorising covered exports and prohibits certain transfers under the conditions set out in the Treaty. Its application to a particular drone, component or system depends on the Treaty's definitions and the facts of the transfer. It should not be presented as a comprehensive treaty covering every type of autonomous targeting software or dual use component.

- ## Accountability under international law

  A state may incur international responsibility where conduct attributable to it breaches an international obligation. An individual may incur criminal responsibility where the elements of a recognised crime and the relevant jurisdictional requirements are established. The use of an autonomous system does not automatically remove either form of responsibility, but it may complicate the factual investigation of an incident. A sound accountability framework may require reliable operational records, clear command arrangements, appropriate training, testing, and procedures for investigating suspected violations. The legal responsibility of any particular person or state must be

determined from the evidence and the applicable rules, rather than presumed from their general involvement in the system's development or use.

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

The development of autonomous weapons has evolved alongside advances in military technology, automation and artificial intelligence. Early automated defence systems were designed to respond to specific threats, while later developments enabled military systems to perform increasingly complex tasks with reduced human intervention. As these capabilities expanded, concerns grew over civilian protection, accountability and the extent of human control over the use of force.

International discussions gained momentum in the 2010s, particularly through the **Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)**. In 2013, the CCW began considering emerging technologies in the area of lethal autonomous weapons systems (LAWS). In 2016, States established a Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) to examine the issues raised by these weapons, including their legal, ethical and humanitarian implications.

In 2019, the GGE affirmed guiding principles, including that international humanitarian law continues to apply to all weapons systems and that human responsibility for decisions on the use of force must be maintained. However, States have continued to disagree over whether existing international law is sufficient or whether a new legally binding instrument is necessary.

The issue subsequently received greater attention within the United Nations General Assembly. In 2023, the General Assembly adopted **Resolution A/RES/78/241**, requesting the Secretary-General to seek the views of Member States on autonomous weapons systems and report on their concerns and perspectives. This was followed by **Resolution A/RES/79/62 in 2024** and **Resolution A/RES/80/57 in 2025**, reflecting the continuing international debate over the security, humanitarian, legal and ethical implications of these technologies.

The UN counterterrorism framework is relevant to preventing terrorist acquisition and misuse of unmanned aircraft systems. The 2024 global report produced by the UN Office of Counter Terrorism and Conflict Armament Research provides a useful evidence base on how non State armed groups obtain and use these systems. The report concerns unmanned aircraft systems broadly and should not be cited as proof that all such systems are autonomous weapons.

Despite these developments, international agreement remains incomplete. States continue to differ on the definition of autonomous weapons, the level of human control required, the need for prohibitions or restrictions, and how existing international law should be applied. Proliferation concerns, the possible acquisition of such systems by non-State actors, unintended escalation and accountability remain central to the debate.

KEY DEFINITIONS

1. Autonomous Weapon Systems (AWS): Weapon systems that, once activated, can select and engage targets without further human intervention. There is currently no universally agreed international definition of AWS.

2. Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS): A term used in international discussions to refer to autonomous weapon systems capable of applying lethal force. The precise scope of the term remains under discussion.

3. Artificial Intelligence (AI): Technologies that enable computer systems to perform tasks associated with human intelligence, such as recognizing patterns, processing information and making predictions. An AI-enabled weapon is not necessarily autonomous.

4. Automation vs Autonomy: Automation involves performing predefined functions according to established rules, whereas autonomy allows a system to perform certain functions independently after activation. The distinction depends on the system's capabilities and the degree of human intervention.

5. Human Control: The ability of humans to exercise appropriate judgement, supervision and intervention over a weapon system's use of force. The level and nature of control required remain central issues in international negotiations.

6. International Humanitarian Law (IHL): The body of international law governing conduct during armed conflict. It includes rules protecting civilians and restricting the means and methods of warfare.

7. Proliferation: The spread or transfer of weapons and related capabilities to additional States or other actors. In this agenda, particular concern surrounds unauthorized transfers and possible acquisition by non-State actors.

8. Non-State Actors: Entities that are not States, including armed groups and terrorist organizations. Their potential access to autonomous weapon technologies raises concerns about security, accountability and international cooperation.

9. Accountability: The obligation to establish responsibility for decisions and actions, including violations of international law involving autonomous systems. The use of autonomous technology does not, by itself, eliminate the legal responsibilities of States or individuals.

10. Meaningful Human Control: A concept emphasizing that human judgement and responsibility must remain significant in decisions concerning the use of force. States differ on its precise requirements and how it should be implemented.

KEY DISTINCTIONS

- **AI-enabled weapons vs autonomous weapons:** AI describes a set of technologies; autonomy concerns the degree to which a weapon performs functions independently.
- **Remote-controlled vs autonomous weapons:** Remote-controlled weapons depend on human operation, while autonomous weapons can perform specified targeting functions without further human intervention.
- **Automated defence vs autonomous targeting:** A system that automatically detects or intercepts a particular threat is not necessarily equivalent to a system that independently selects targets in a wider operational environment.
- **Autonomy vs accountability:** Greater technical independence does not mean that legal responsibility disappears

- **Regulation vs prohibition:** Regulation places conditions and limits on permitted systems or uses; prohibition rules out specified systems or activities.
- **Political declarations vs binding law:** UN resolutions and negotiated political commitments do not automatically create the same legal obligations as binding treaties.

  These distinctions are essential because international negotiations depend not only on the capabilities of a weapon, but also on how it is defined, controlled, deployed and regulated under international law.

CURRENT STATE OF AFFAIRS

When shifting into something like virtual weapons, if there was even before some formation of an interaction between humans and weapons, those are gone. After the late 2026 formal acknowledgment of the United Nations Group of Governmental Experts (GGE), lethal autonomous weapon systems (LAWS) were defined as platforms capable of selecting, tracking, and attacking without human intervention.

Metrics for Defense Market Globalization and Proliferation

The race for the swift development of autonomous weaponry has been backed by an unprecedented wealth of financial investment into the defense software and automated platform:

- **The Autonomous Fleet Expansion:** The wider global drone warfare market is set at becoming much more expansive, with the estimated figures having reached some $21.3 billion. At the same time, the farmer resultantly specialized military swarm drone market saw a growth from $1.0 billion to $1.23 billion, growing at an insane CAGR of 23.3%.

- **Strategically defund**: Major militaries are transferring huge amounts of capital from traditional military hardware into automated infrastructures. The U.S. Department of Defense spent a record $13.4 billion specifically on autonomous and remote-controlled systems for use in air, land, and sea

- **The Counter-Weapon Dilemma:** the global Counter-Unmanned Aerial System (C-UAS) market is projected to surge from $13.7 billion to $16.9 billion, maintaining a massive 22.7% CAGR.

Operational Reality on the Battlefield

- **The conflict in ukraine:** With the creation of its unmanned system forces Ukraine manufactures millions of low-cost drones equipped with AI-driven terminal guidance systems designed to bypass electronic jamming.

- **The Middle East:** Extensive reporting highlights the military deployment of AI-assisted data-processing networks such as the *Gospel* and *Lavender* systems to accelerate targeting cycles, raising serious ethical dilemmas regarding the erosion of human supervision in high-stakes operational environments.

- **The Terrorist/Non-State Proliferation Crisis:** The commercial off-the-shelf nature of drone technology and open-source AI algorithms has drastically lowered barriers to entry. Non-state actors, including insurgent groups in the Middle East and Africa, are actively weaponizing consumer hardware, raising concerns that autonomous "fire-and-forget" systems could soon be used to conduct deniable, untraceable terrorist attacks without the need for sophisticated military infrastructure.

  Jamming Immunity: Traditional counter-drone defenses rely on cutting radio frequencies or GPS connections. A fully autonomous drone using computer vision does not rely on external communications, making it completely immune to radio electronic countermeasures.

The Diplomatic Battleground

The primary multilateral forum for regulation is the **UN Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)**. In September 2026, the UN GGE on LAWS concluded its rigorous three-year mandate in Geneva. While a consensus text on the

functional description of autonomous weapons was achieved, a fractured geopolitical landscape continues to stall a comprehensive, legally binding international treaty.

Frustrated by over a decade of consensus-driven stalling within the CCW framework, the **Humanitarian Coalition**—a vast majority bloc of **130 nations** across Latin America, Africa, and parts of Europe, heavily supported by the International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) and the stop killer robots campaign—has begun bypassing the Geneva tracks completely.

STAKE-HOLDER ANALYSIS

The debate over LAWS is split between major military powers prioritizing national security and strategic deterrence, and a broad coalition of states advocating for strict humanitarian protections.

- **UNITED STATES OF AMERICA:**regulated integration.washington rejects blanket bans,asserting that AI driven precision reduces collateral damage.Focuses on “appropriate levels of human judgment” rather than permanent manual locks.

Governed by the newly updated DOD Directive 3000.09 Pushing forward with its Replicator Initiative to field thousands of cheap, attritable autonomous air and sea drones.
A core driver of this budget is the **Replicator Initiative**, a strategic program designed to rapidly field **thousands of low-cost, attritable, autonomous systems** within an 18 to 24-month window to offset the mass-production capabilities of strategic competitors.

- **THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION:** The Russian Federation maintains a doctrine of Total Strategic Non-Cooperation within multilateral regulatory forums. Moscow systematically objects to any binding international legal mechanisms, definitions, or independent verification processes that could restrict its domestic research, development, and industrial output.
  The **Lancet** **Loitering Munition** represents the physical execution of this doctrine. It is an operational platform built specifically to exploit autonomy when human remote control is no longer possible,

These platforms are equipped with onboard autonomous target-recognition modules that allow them to independently navigate, track, and strike targets in highly contested, heavily electronic-jammed zones where human-in-the-loop radio controls are completely cut off.

- **PEOPLE'S REPUBLIC OF CHINA;**China pursues a calculated, dual-track diplomatic strategy. Politically, Beijing officially supports an international ban on the *battlefield deployment* of fully autonomous weapons systems, presenting itself as a responsible global power aligned with humanitarian concerns. However, the state firmly defends its absolute right to *research, develop, test, and manufacture* these technologies, ensuring its domestic defense programs face zero restrictions.
- **STATE OF ISRAEL:**Tel Aviv strongly opposes international legal bans or top-down restrictive treaties, maintaining that highly complex urban environments and modern counter-terrorism operations require reaction times that humans cannot physically achieve. Israel's defense doctrine treats automated combat capabilities as a baseline requirement for national survival against asymmetric threats.
  Israel operates at the leading edge of sensor-to-shooter automation. The state has integrated highly sophisticated AI-driven data-processing frameworks, most notably the **Gospel** and **Lavender** networks, into its active military workflows. The Gospel system functions as a high-speed target recommendation matrix; while human teams historically bottlenecked targeting to roughly 50 objectives per year in dense urban settings, these automated networks produce recommendations at a velocity that allows forces to generate target profiles for up to **100 objectives per day**. The Lavender system generated a database of **37,000 individuals** flagged as suspected targets, with human operators spending an average of just **20 seconds** reviewing each profile before authorizing lethal deployment.

- **The International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) & Civil Society :**As the legal guardian of the Geneva Conventions, the ICRC, alongside civil society alliances like the Stop Killer Robots Campaign, They assert that machines lack the human capacity to

judge context, distinguish between active combatants and surrendering soldiers, or evaluate the proportionality of a civilian strike.
he ICRC acts as an expert advisory body to the United Nations, publishing comprehensive legal and technical white papers designed to define the boundaries of **"Meaningful Human Control."** They advocate for a complete ban on the integration of machine learning algorithms into the targeting software of kinetic weapons, warning that self-programming software creates an unpredictable "black box" that can never comply with international law

CORE ISSUES OF THE AGENDA

Autonomous weapon systems raise questions that extend beyond military technology. They concern who makes decisions about the use of lethal force, how civilians are protected, who is accountable when an attack is unlawful, and whether weapons and related technologies can spread to terrorist organisations or other non state actors.

The issue is not whether every use of autonomy is unlawful. It is whether particular systems can be used predictably and responsibly within the limits of international law. A necessary distinction: a remotely piloted drone is controlled by a person; an automated system follows pre set rules; an autonomous weapon can select and engage a target without further human intervention after activation. These categories can overlap technically, but they are not interchangeable.

The General Assembly adopted Resolution A/RES/80/57 on lethal autonomous weapon systems on 1 December 2025 by 164 votes to 6, with 7 abstentions. Separately, SIPRI estimated global military expenditure at US$2.887 trillion in 2025. The spending figure is context for the wider security environment, not an estimate of autonomous weapons spending. Sources: UN Digital Library; SIPRI, April 2026.

1. Civilian protection and The human cost of war

International Humanitarian Law requires parties to an armed conflict to distinguish civilians from combatants, avoid attacks expected to cause excessive incidental civilian harm in relation to the anticipated concrete and direct military advantage, and take feasible precautions to reduce harm. These obligations apply to weapons that incorporate autonomous functions as well as to weapons operated directly by people. Autonomous systems may process information quickly, but speed alone does not establish that a system can interpret the context of an attack. A person carrying an object that resembles a weapon, for example, may not be a lawful target in the circumstances. A person

may also be wounded, surrendering or otherwise entitled to protection. A system that recognises an object accurately may still lack the contextual information needed to support a lawful targeting decision. Supporters argue that some automated functions may improve detection or reduce certain forms of human error. The humanitarian effect therefore depends on the specific system, the environment in which it is used, the information available to decision makers and the safeguards in place

2. Accountability and unlawful outcomes

When an autonomous weapon causes harm, responsibility does not transfer to the machine. Legal responsibility may arise for a state or an individual, depending on the conduct, the applicable legal rules and the evidence. The difficult question is how to establish what happened when decisions are distributed across system design, testing, authorisation, deployment and operation. An investigation may need to establish what the system was designed to do, what information it received, what instructions governed its use, whether known limitations were ignored, and whether a human decision maker could reasonably have prevented the harm.

Preserving Autonomous Weapons operational records and making system behaviour sufficiently explainable may be essential to a credible investigation. State responsibility, individual criminal responsibility and any domestic civil or administrative liability are distinct legal questions. A developer, operator or commander is not automatically liable merely because they were involved. Responsibility must be assessed against the applicable legal standard and the facts of the incident.

3. Escalation and strategic instability

Autonomous functions may shorten the time between detecting a perceived threat and responding to it. In some defensive settings, rapid responses may offer operational advantages. In a tense or confusing encounter, however, rapid automated action may leave less time for human verification, communication or de escalation. An error could be interpreted as a deliberate attack and prompt retaliation before the circumstances are understood.

The risk is not limited to technical malfunction. States may feel pressure to deploy increasingly automated systems because they fear that a slower response will leave them at a disadvantage. Such dynamics can intensify competition and complicate crisis management. Delegates should consider safeguards such as defined operating limits, reliable communication channels, incident reporting and human authorisation for decisions with a high risk of escalation.

4. Transparency and verification

Autonomous capability can depend on software, sensor configuration and operating settings, making it harder to assess a system's behaviour from its external appearance alone. Verification is therefore likely to require more than visual inspection. States could exchange information about doctrine, testing standards, weapons review procedures and safeguards, while protecting genuinely sensitive technical information

Autonomous Weapons Transparency measures cannot by themselves prove that a weapon complies with international law. They can, however, help states understand one another's practices, identify areas of common ground and build confidence while negotiations continue.

Case study: The Kargu 2 system in Libya

The UN Panel of Experts on Libya reported in 2021 on the use of unmanned systems during the conflict, including a system described as capable of engaging targets without a data link to an operator. The report is frequently discussed in debates about a possible deployment of an autonomous weapon. It does not conclusively establish that the system independently selected and killed a person in the specific incident. The case should therefore be described as a reported deployment that raised concerns, not as proven evidence of the first autonomous killing. Why the case matters: it illustrates the difficulty of establishing what a weapon actually did in the field, what degree of autonomy was used, and what evidence would be needed to assess legal responsibility.
Primary source: UN Security Council, Final report of the Panel of Experts on Libya, S/2021/229 (2021). SECTION 8

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER?

1. Are existing international rules sufficient for all foreseeable uses of autonomous weapons, or is a new instrument necessary?

2. Should specific systems or uses be prohibited because they cannot be used consistently with International Humanitarian Law?

3. What minimum requirements should apply to human judgement, supervision and the ability to intervene?

4. How can states improve weapons reviews while protecting genuinely sensitive information?

5. Which export controls and cooperation measures could reduce diversion to terrorist organisations?

6. What information should be preserved and shared after an incident involving an autonomous weapon?

7.Should the committee prioritise a binding treaty, practical restrictions under existing law, or a combination of both?

8. Which capabilities or uses should be prohibited, and how should those categories be defined?

9. What evidence should a state provide to show that its weapons review is credible?

10. How can export controls address diversion without imposing unnecessary restrictions on lawful civilian technology?

11.What information should states share after an incident, and how should sensitive information be protected?

12. How can developing states receive technical assistance and participate meaningfully in implementation?

POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS AND POLICY DIRECTIONS

States could negotiate prohibitions on autonomous weapons whose effects cannot be sufficiently understood, predicted or controlled, or whose use cannot comply with applicable international law. A separate set of rules could regulate systems that remain permissible. The central challenge would be to define the prohibited category clearly enough to avoid loopholes while ensuring that legitimate defensive technologies are not unintentionally included.

- Establish a standard for meaningful human control

An international standard could require humans to retain sufficient information, time and authority to make responsible decisions about the use of force. It could address the authorisation of engagements, the ability to monitor a system, the power to intervene or abort, and the environments in which autonomous functions may be used. A meaningful standard must go beyond requiring a person to press an approval button. The decision maker must be able to understand relevant limitations, question the system's output and take effective action. States would need to agree on practical requirements while recognising that the appropriate safeguards may depend on the system and its operational context.

- Strengthen legal reviews of new weapons

States could improve national weapons review procedures by sharing methodologies, developing common technical guidance and reviewing systems when significant software or capability changes are introduced. Reviews should examine the system's predictability, ability to distinguish lawful targets, foreseeable failure modes, limits on operation, human oversight and procedures for withdrawing a system if problems emerge. This approach builds on existing law rather than assuming a new treaty is the only solution. Article 36 of Additional Protocol I already requires reviews for States Parties to that Protocol. Wider exchange of good practices could help states that do not have mature review systems, while allowing each state to protect genuinely sensitive technical information

- Reduce terrorist acquisition and diversion

States could strengthen risk based export licensing, end user checks and cooperation against illicit procurement. The focus should be on preventing diversion of relevant weapons, components and capabilities to terrorist organisations, while preserving legitimate civilian uses of unmanned aircraft and dual use technology. A practical package could include information sharing about known procurement patterns, assistance to border and law enforcement authorities, reporting of suspected diversion, and technical support for states that lack effective counter drone capacity. These measures should be designed around evidence of risk rather than blanket restrictions on all commercial drones.

- Improve transparency and crisis communication

States could exchange information about national policies, weapons review procedures, safeguards and relevant incidents. Regular expert meetings and agreed terminology would help identify areas of common ground. Communication channels and incident reporting could also reduce the chance that a technical failure or unexpected action is misread as a deliberate attack. Transparency is not a substitute for binding rules or independent investigation, and states may be reluctant to disclose sensitive details. Reporting arrangements should therefore specify what information is shared, with whom, and how confidential material is protected

- Build capacity and support implementation

International standards will be less effective if only a small number of states can implement them. Technical workshops, shared legal guidance and training for military legal advisers, procurement officials and investigators could help states assess autonomous systems and respond to incidents. Capacity building should include developing countries and states that face elevated risks from weaponised drones but lack resources for detection and response.

- **A practical drafting test**

A strong resolution should do more than call for further discussion. Delegates should identify the problem being addressed, define the systems or conduct covered, assign realistic implementation tasks, and specify how progress will be reviewed. If the draft proposes human control, it should explain what that means in practice: who authorises use, what information must be available, when intervention must remain possible, and which environments require tighter limits. If it proposes counterterrorism measures, it should address diversion risks without treating every commercial drone as a weapon. Before submitting a clause, ask: Is the obligation clear? Is it legally and technically feasible? Who implements it? How could states assess whether it is working?

APPENDIX

Appendix A. Timeline of key developments

Year	Event	Significance
1949	Adoption of the Four Geneva Conventions	Established fundamental protections for persons affected by armed conflict, including wounded and sick soldiers, prisoners of war, and civilians.
1977	Adoption of Additional Protocols I and II	Additional Protocol I established rules concerning the conduct of hostilities,

		including distinction, civilian protection, precautions in attack, and the review of new weapons.
2013	Dedicated discussions on Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS) began under the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)	Brought the challenges posed by emerging autonomous weapons into a multilateral disarmament forum.
2016	Establishment of the CCW Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) on LAWS	Created a dedicated forum for examining the legal, humanitarian, ethical, and security implications of autonomous weapons.
2019	Affirmation of the GGE guiding principles on LAWS	Reaffirmed that International Humanitarian Law (IHL) applies to emerging weapons technologies and emphasised the need to maintain human responsibility.
2021	Publication of UN Panel of Experts report on Libya (S/2021/229)	Discussed an incident involving an unmanned system in Libya, which became an important reference in debates about autonomous engagement.
2023	Adoption of UN General Assembly Resolution A/RES/78/241	Advanced international consideration of autonomous weapons systems and their legal, humanitarian, and security implications.
2024	Adoption of UN General Assembly Resolution A/RES/79/62	Continued UN deliberations on the risks, challenges, and potential regulation of autonomous weapons systems.
2025	Adoption of UN General Assembly Resolution A/RES/80/57 on 1 December	The resolution was adopted by 164 votes in favour, 6 against, and 7 abstentions, reflecting broad international concern about autonomous weapons, including the risks of proliferation and escalation.

APPENDIX:B Organisation

and their Roles

UNGA First Committee (DISEC): Debates disarmament and international security and makes recommendations to the General Assembly.

UN Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA): Supports multilateral disarmament processes and publishes official documents

Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons: Provides the main multilateral forum for LAWS discussions.

International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC): Provides expert analysis on International Humanitarian Law and humanitarian concerns

UN Office of Counter Terrorism (UNOCT) : Supports international counterterrorism cooperation and publishes research on terrorist use of unmanned aircraft systems.

Conflict Armament Research (CAR): Documents weapons and components, including those acquired or used by armed groups

Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) :Publishes research on military expenditure, arms transfers and international security

APPENDIX:C Selected Roles for the Delegates

Selected Sources for Delegates

The sources listed below provide reliable starting points for verifying claims, preparing country positions, and locating primary documents relevant to the agenda. Delegates are encouraged to consult the original resolutions, reports, and legal materials wherever possible. Access dates are not included, as some webpages may be updated periodically.

1. **United Nations General Assembly.** *Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems*, Resolution A/RES/80/57 (2025). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4095989
2. **United Nations General Assembly.** Resolution A/RES/79/62 (2024). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4071100
3. **United Nations General Assembly.** Resolution A/RES/78/241 (2023). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4033027

4. **United Nations Security Council.** *Final Report of the Panel of Experts on Libya*, S/2021/229 (2021). https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/3905159
5. **United Nations Office of Counter-Terrorism and Conflict Armament Research.** *Global Report on the Acquisition, Weaponization and Deployment of Unmanned Aircraft Systems by Non-State Armed Groups for Terrorism-Related Purposes* (2024). https://www.un.org/counterterrorism/en/2023-global-report-acquisition-weaponization-and-deployment-unmanned-aircraft-systems-uas
6. **Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI).** *Trends in World Military Expenditure, 2025* (April 2026). https://www.sipri.org/publications/2026/sipri-fact-sheets/trends-world-military-expenditure-2025
7. **International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC).** *Autonomous Weapon Systems: Frequently Asked Questions and Legal Policy Materials.* https://www.icrc.org/en/war-and-law/weapons/autonomous-weapons
8. **United Nations.** *Charter of the United Nations: Full Text.* https://www.un.org/en/about-us/un-charter/full-text
9. **International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC).** *A Guide to the Legal Review of New Weapons, Means and Methods of Warfare.* https://www.icrc.org/en/publication/0902-guide-legal-review-new-weapons-means-and-methods-warfare-measures-implement-article